



# PRELIMINARY RESEARCH REPORT

## Assurance and Investment Prioritisation for Digital Capability Uplift in the New Zealand Public Service

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## Executive Summary

The New Zealand Government is pursuing significant fiscal and digital reform to improve public sector productivity, reduce duplication, and deliver modern citizen-centric services. Cabinet has now centralised oversight of digital investment and procurement under the Government Chief Digital Officer (GCDO) within the Department of Internal Affairs (DIA), seeking \$1.2–\$3.6 billion in savings from a \$13 billion digital pipeline over five years. Technology, however, cannot achieve these outcomes unless the workforce has the digital capability required to deliver and sustain transformation. The Digital Workforce Programme was established to address this need.

This report supports the review of the Digital Capability in the Public Service Workforce initiative at the mid-implementation stage by examining the challenge through a governance and investment-assurance lens. The core research question asks: How can DIA move from voluntary capability guidance to measurable assurance, so that major digital investments demonstrate value, reduce delivery risk, and uphold Cabinet-level accountability?

Evidence indicates a systemic capability gap. Uplift remains uneven and difficult to measure because capability frameworks and assessment practices remain voluntary, inconsistently applied, and rarely integrated into investment or workforce planning. Consequently, DIA lacks a reliable, system-wide view of digital capability or its contribution to strategic outcomes, value creation, delivery confidence, or risk reduction. External pressures intensify urgency. Government reporting shows 85% of digital programmes are rated high-risk, and 59% are delayed or challenged. Global cybersecurity shortages may reach 85 million workers by 2030, driving contractor dependency that erodes institutional knowledge. Under fiscal constraint, discretionary practice is no longer viable.

Root-cause analysis confirms the issue is not a lack of frameworks but the absence of enforceable investment mechanisms. Because capability evidence is not required at capital-approval gates, agencies lack incentives to conduct structured analysis. Comparative practice shows that jurisdictions like the Australian Public Service embed mandatory capability oversight throughout the investment lifecycle to enforce alignment, manage risk, and improve portfolio performance.

This report recommends a transition from discretionary guidance to a mandatory capability assurance gate. By leveraging the new centralised investment authority, the DIA should require strategy-matching capability analysis as a prerequisite for the approval of all large digital capital projects (exceeding a set financial threshold). This approach involves:

- SFIA-aligned capability assessments embedded in business cases;
- a tiered prioritisation matrix weighting Measurable Organisational Value (MOV), delivery-risk reduction, and capability-gap closure;
- light-touch reporting templates for CIOs/CEs; and
- early monitoring of capability-risk indicators to support Cabinet-level oversight.

This proportionate, investment-linked approach ensures funding flows only to initiatives that can evidence fiscal benefit, reduced delivery risk, and enduring workforce capacity. It provides a defensible foundation for the next stage of solution design and directly supports the GCDO mandate to deliver a coherent, fiscally responsible, digitally capable Public Service.

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# 1 Introduction

## 1.1 Strategic Context: The Imperative for Fiscal and Digital Reform

The New Zealand Government has embarked on a significant reform agenda aimed at improving fiscal discipline, service quality, and productivity across the Public Service (Department of Internal Affairs [DIA], 2020; Public Service Commission, 2024). Cabinet has now mandated centralised oversight of most digital investment and procurement under the Government Chief Digital Officer (GCDO) within the DIA (DIA, 2025). The intent is to stop duplicative solutions, shift toward reusable platforms, and realise \$1.2–\$3.6 billion in savings across the \$13 billion ICT pipeline over the next five years (DIA 2020, 2025).

Technology alone will not deliver those outcomes. Workforce capability determines whether transformation succeeds. The GCDO aims to build a digitally capable public service using evidence-based approaches, recognising that without the right skills, technological investment risks yielding poor outcomes and creating waste (NZ Digital Government [NZDG], 2025a). This context places the Digital Workforce Programme at the centre of the government’s broader digital reform agenda.

## 1.2 Research Focus: The Governance and Assurance Lens

This report contributes to the review of DIA’s Digital Workforce Program by examining the challenge through a governance, assurance, and investment prioritisation lens. Rather than assessing technology or training, it examines how capability is governed, measured, and linked to investment and risk. My research explores mechanisms for introducing clear, value-based investment prioritisation criteria so scarce public funding is directed toward workforce capability that improves delivery confidence and protects public value. This approach leverages the newly centralised digital investment mandate as the enforcement mechanism needed to move from voluntary guidance to measurable assurance.

The report clarifies the problem and establishes the evidence base for solution design. It aims to:

- explain why capability uplift is uneven and hard to measure system-wide;
- analyse how that weakens investment assurance, delivery confidence, and value realisation;
- outline initial goals for strengthening governance consistent with Cabinet-level scrutiny and All-of-Government (AoG) fiscal accountability.

Should DIA or associated stakeholders wish to discuss any aspect of the analysis or explore how these insights could inform next-phase policy or investment design, I would welcome further engagement.

The following section sets out the background context and urgency of the problem, drawing on evidence from current policy settings, investment data, and system-wide capability trends.

# 2 Background and Problem Definition

## 2.1 Problem Statement: Capability Without Assurance

DIA, acting as the Government Chief Digital Officer (GCDO), requires clearer insight into the Digital Capability in the Public Service Workforce initiative at its mid-implementation stage. Early evidence indicates that digital capability uplift is progressing unevenly across Public Service agencies, as capability frameworks and assessment practices remain voluntary, inconsistent, and only partially embedded. This variability limits DIA’s ability to form a reliable, system-wide view of workforce digital capability and to demonstrate how capability development contributes to Digital Strategy for Government outcomes, value creation, and delivery risk reduction.

This lack of assurance is increasingly problematic as digital investment decisions are being centralised and subjected to heightened scrutiny. In an environment where the Cabinet expects AoG initiatives to deliver demonstrable value and manage delivery risk effectively, the absence of consistent capability evidence represents a material governance gap. These pressures make it essential to examine the broader operating circumstances now shaping the urgency and impact of this problem.

## 2.2 Circumstances: Risk, Talent and Fiscal Constraints

System pressures now intensify the consequences of uneven capability: 85% of the \$13 billion digital pipeline is rated high-risk, with 59% already delayed or challenged (DIA, 2025), and capability shortfalls remain a material delivery threat. At the same time, the Public Service faces an acute talent squeeze: global cyber-security shortages may reach 85 million workers by 2030 (Meineke, 2024), fuelling contractor dependence that weakens long-term capability (NZDG, 2025b; OECD, 2021). Cabinet’s centralisation of digital investment under fiscal constraint (New Zealand Government, 2025) means DIA must now demonstrate measurable value and risk mitigation, not voluntary practice. These pressures, summarised in Table 1 – PESTLE analysis, reinforce the need for a mandatory assurance mechanism rather than discretionary guidance.

| Factor                | Core Pressure                                                                                                                           | Implication                                                                                                                |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Political</b>      | Cabinet has centralised digital investment and procurement under the GCDO to unlock savings and reduce duplication.                     | Requires mandatory compliance at investment approval gates to legitimise the GCDO’s system-led authority.                  |
| <b>Economic</b>       | A \$13 billion pipeline is unaffordable, and agencies face escalating contractor costs and workforce reductions.                        | Funding must prioritise MOV/ROI-driven capability investment that reduces costly contractor reliance and delivery failure. |
| <b>Socio-Cultural</b> | High public expectations for modern digital services and Te Tiriti-aligned capability; critical shortages exist in AI, data, and cyber. | Assurance must validate specialised skill pathways and cultural competency before approving major investments.             |
| <b>Technological</b>  | Rapid adoption of AI, cloud, and cybersecurity increases delivery complexity; legacy replacement is urgent for 75% of agencies.         | Governance must ensure future-skills planning to avoid high-risk outsourcing and legacy cost escalation.                   |
| <b>Legal</b>          | Governance must ensure future-skills planning to avoid high-risk outsourcing and legacy cost escalation.                                | Capability checks must verify qualified personnel for security, data governance, and privacy before capital approval.      |
| <b>Internal</b>       | 85% of projects are high-risk; capability frameworks are voluntary and inconsistently applied across agencies.                          | A mandatory capability assurance requirement becomes essential for controlling delivery risk and investment failure.       |

**Table 1. PESTLE Analysis - External and Internal Drivers for Change**

## 2.3 Root Cause Analysis: The Failure of Voluntary Adoption

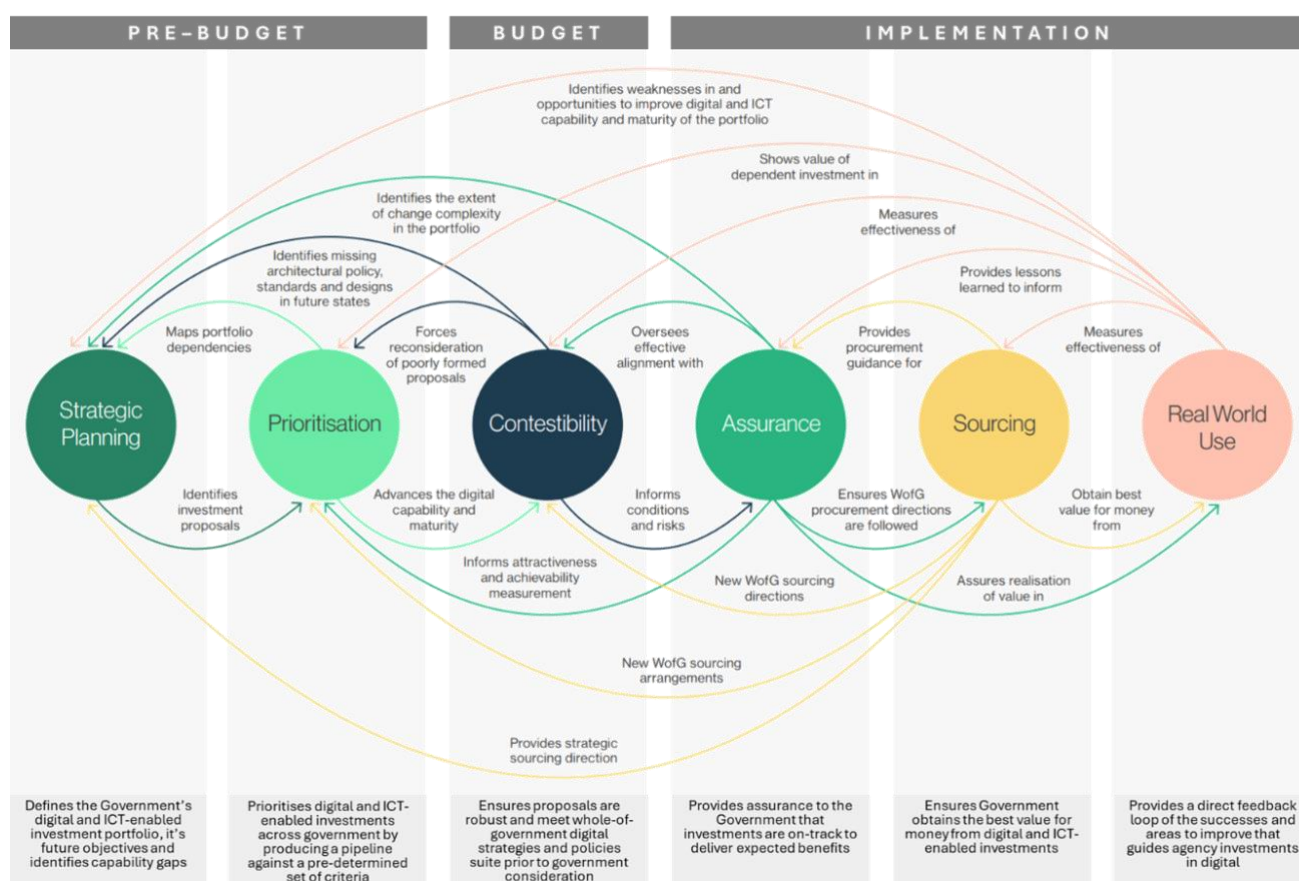
The underlying cause is not the absence of frameworks, but the absence of enforceable governance mechanisms. SFIA-NZ exists, DIA evidence indicates that only around 20% of agencies actively use SFIA, and even fewer integrate it into core investment or workforce planning processes (NZDG, 2025c). Because capability assessment is not required at key approval gates, there is little incentive to perform structured capability analysis. Figure 1 summarises a Five-Whys analysis, showing how high-risk and underperforming digital projects’ symptoms trace back to the structural root cause: capability assurance is decoupled from investment decision-making.

This voluntary model is insufficient to meet current system expectations. DIA cannot reliably assess delivery readiness for high-risk projects, coordinate capability development in support of shared platforms, or consistently demonstrate measurable values to the Cabinet. Consequently, the absence of a policy–process combination linking capability assurance to investment approval represents the central governance failure constraining the effectiveness of the Digital Workforce Programme. These structural limitations are not unique to New Zealand. The following section examines how leading jurisdictions have addressed similar challenges.



## 2.4 Comparative Governance: The Case for Mandatory Assurance

The challenge of aligning diverse, autonomous agencies toward a unified digital goal is common among OECD nations. OECD (2021) emphasises that system stewardship requires leaders to enforce capability conditions rather than rely on guidance alone. The Australian Public Service (APS) provides a clear precedent: it embeds mandatory capability oversight within the investment lifecycle. Figure 2 demonstrates an end-to-end APS Investment Oversight Framework model where agencies must submit digital investment plans, undergo contestability review before capital approval, and align capability planning with a Digital Government Target State (Australian Government, 2024; 2025; Gill & Hansnata, 2024). CFO-level scrutiny links workforce capability directly to delivery assurance.



**Figure 2. Investment Oversight Framework**



This external reference reinforces the logic that GCDO intervention is not punitive, but a standard international practice for managing high-risk government technology spending. Furthermore, the New Zealand Public Service Commission (2023) explicitly notes that Capability Reviews support chief executives in building capable agencies and achieving better outcomes, positioning capability assessment as an important system leadership role.

These international trends confirm that capability assurance is no longer discretionary, it is a pre-condition for credible investment governance. With the structural problem and external precedents established, the next step is to determine what value must be demonstrated, how capability should be prioritised, and what governance settings will incentivise compliance. Section 3 now evaluates these requirements through value drivers, alignment mechanisms, and implementation constraints.

### 3 Discussion of Initial Analysis and Considerations

#### 3.1 Value Drivers: Defining Success Through MOV, CCV and Risk

For central decision-makers operating under fiscal discipline, capability investment must demonstrate measurable value rather than activity. The task is to convert skill uplift into quantifiable cost avoidance, reduced delivery risk, and visible performance benefits for agencies and citizens. In short, capability must prove it saves money, strengthens delivery confidence, and advances strategic outcomes.

Table 2 operationalises this shift by weighting criteria that matter most at the investment gate - MOV, delivery-risk reduction, and closing capability gaps for high-value capital projects. Supporting criteria (CCV, strategic alignment) reinforce system priorities and citizen outcomes. These drivers ensure funding flows only to initiatives that can evidence system-wide benefit and reduced delivery risk.

| Criterion                                    | Value Driver                                                                         | Measurement Link                                                                                                      | Priority |
|----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| <b>MOV</b>                                   | Fiscal stewardship; removal of duplication and contractor-dependence.                | Quantifiable cost avoidance, efficiency gains, faster time-to-hire, and internal capability uplift.                   | High     |
| <b>Project Delivery Risk Reduction</b>       | Increase delivery confidence for high-risk digital projects.                         | Independent risk-rating improvement attributable to capability plans aligned with SFIA-NZ.                            | High     |
| <b>Strategic Alignment</b>                   | Compliance with centralised investment rules; alignment to DS4G and common platforms | % of investment tied to reuse, shared services, procurement mandates, Te Tiriti obligations.                          | High     |
| <b>CCV</b>                                   | Citizen-facing or agency-facing benefit delivery                                     | Reduced service failures, fewer outages/bugs, improved adoption and satisfaction.                                     | Medium   |
| <b>Future Skills/Capability Gap Severity</b> | Address acute skill shortages and leverage capital investments                       | % investment dedicated to reskilling/ upskilling permanent staff; scale of maturity gap against project requirements. | Medium   |
| <b>UCV</b>                                   | Front-line confidence, service usability, workforce engagement                       | Uptake rates, satisfaction indicators, and qualitative user feedback.                                                 | Low      |

**Table 2. Proposed Investment Prioritisation Criteria**

#### 3.2 Strategic Alignment and Enforceable Standards

International practice shows that alignment is never achieved through guidance alone. In the APS, the Digital and ICT IOF mandates agency digital plans and robust assurance activities across the entire project lifecycle, ensuring alignment with a central target state. The APS model directly supports the allocation of resources by improving visibility and reducing delivery risk. To mirror this successful approach, two proportionate interventions emerge for DIA:

1. Require all major digital capital projects to submit evidence of a planned capability gap analysis.
2. Apply a Prioritisation Matrix to ensure resources flow to solutions, reducing delivery risk and maximising public value.

This approach transforms the GCDO's role from merely guiding actively certifying the capability component of an investment proposal as fit-for-purpose.

### 3.3 Constraints and User Requirements

A single, universal capability framework would be counterproductive given the varied agency maturity and project complexity. Therefore, successful implementation requires an approach that enables compliance, limits resistance, and embeds discipline only where it delivers measurable value:

- **Avoid "Cookie-Cutter" Solutions:** The mandate must therefore target project-specific capability planning, allowing agencies to build or buy scarce skills rather than conform to a rigid template.
- **Scaling the Mandate:** To remain proportionate, capability assessment should scale only to large or high-risk capital projects, where assurance matters most.
- **Leader Literacy:** The framework must clearly define what capability is and offer low-effort mechanisms for reporting to address uneven senior digital literacy. The mechanism must provide simple reporting tools with clear criteria, concise templates, and MOV-and risk-focused outputs so capability assurance becomes usable rather than burdensome.

These design requirements highlight political and operational sensitivities, creating risks that must be actively mitigated in implementation.

### 3.4 Initial Risk Assessment and Mitigation

Implementing a mandatory capability assurance gate requires careful management of political, organisational, and cultural risk. Table 3 outlines proportionate mitigation strategies, indicating that enforcement can be achieved without bureaucracy by limiting the requirement to high-risk capital investments and leveraging tools that already exist. Importantly, capability governance succeeds when it is targeted, simple to comply with, and builds long-term workforce capacity rather than administrative burden.

| Risk Category                                | Description of Exposure                                                                                         | Description of Exposure                                                                                                                                  |
|----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Political/Cultural Acceptance</b>         | Agencies may resist mandatory capability assurance, perceiving it as a one-size-fits-all compliance burden.     | Apply a proportionate mandate: require capability assessment only for large/high-risk capital projects (e.g., > \$1M) and provide light-touch templates. |
| <b>Measurement Quality &amp; Consistency</b> | Variable or poor-quality capability data weakens assurance and comparability.                                   | Require the SFIA-NZ framework and simple maturity models to create a common language and quantifiable reporting.                                         |
| <b>Capability Supply Constraints</b>         | Mandated assessments may expose shortages in specialist areas (AI, cyber, data), driving contractor dependence. | Mandated assessments may expose shortages in specialist areas (AI, cyber, data), driving contractor dependence.                                          |
| <b>Framework Duplication/ Complexity</b>     | New assurance processes could generate parallel tools and bureaucracy.                                          | Integrate existing assets (SFIA-NZ, Service Modernisation Roadmap) rather than developing bespoke frameworks.                                            |

**Table 3. Initial Risks and Mitigation for a Mandatory Capability Gate**

With these risks addressed, the next step is to define clear objectives that embed capability assurance into investment governance and enable the GCDO to meet the Cabinet's fiscal and delivery expectations.



## 4 Initial Conclusions and Recommended Goals & Objectives

### 4.1 Conclusion: The Necessity of a Mandatory Assurance Gate

The ability of the GCDO/DIA to realise projected cost savings (1.2B–3.6B) and rationalise the high-risk investment pipeline is conditional on enforcing systemic capability assurance. The current voluntary approach has failed to achieve the necessary consistency, as evidenced by the low utilisation of common frameworks. Aligning capability assessment with centralised investment gates is therefore a required governance pivot. It allows DIA to assure the Cabinet that spending is defensible, delivery risk (the expected ROI) is addressed, and MOV/CCV are achievable.

### 4.2 Recommended Goals and Objectives

The transformation has now reached the stage where high-level intent must translate into enforceable investment behaviour. Table 4 consolidates the strategic, tactical, and operational goals needed to embed capability assurance directly into investment governance. These goals and objectives show a staged pathway to ensure the shift is enforceable without creating an administrative burden.

| Level       | Core Goal                                                                                          | Measurable Objectives (What Happens Next)                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|-------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Strategic   | Embed a mandatory digital capability assurance gate for major capital projects by Q4 FY26          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Require capability assessments in investment documentation.</li> <li>Define and publish MOV/ROI/Risk criteria for capability uplift.</li> </ul>                                      |
| Strategic   | Prioritise capability investments based on demonstrated value creation and delivery-risk reduction | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Introduce a tiered Prioritisation Matrix (Value/Risk/Alignment) to score proposals and direct funding to high-impact initiatives.</li> </ul>                                         |
| Tactical    | Standardise how agencies quantify capability needs                                                 | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Mandate an SFIA-aligned capability-gap model for major business cases.</li> <li>Require MOV/CCV/Risk reporting as part of investment planning.</li> </ul>                            |
| Operational | Support immediate agency compliance                                                                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Release light-touch capability-mapping templates for CIOs/CEs.</li> <li>Begin quarterly monitoring of capability-risk indicators in investment intentions (from Q3 FY26).</li> </ul> |

**Table 4. Initial Recommended Goals and Objectives**

## 5 Closing Statement

The research confirms that moving from discretionary guidance to mandatory assurance is essential to safeguard fiscal outcomes and delivery confidence. By adopting mandatory, value-based criteria, DIA can transform capability planning from a fragmented aspiration into an accountable, system-wide strategic mandate. The findings and objectives presented here provide the foundation for developing a detailed proposal to deliver these governance solutions, ensuring the GCDO is equipped to successfully realise both fiscal savings and enduring benefits for New Zealanders in the digital era. This integrated approach is the cornerstone of a coherent, cohesive, and efficient digital future for the Public Service.

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